

deer-vehicle collisions often are marked with deer crossing signs. The New York State Department of Environmental Conservation recommends these precautions motorists can take to reduce the chance of a deer hit:

- Be careful when you drive at dawn and dusk; this is when driver visibility is bad and the deer are most active.
- The risk of deer-vehicle collisions increases when deer movements increase during breeding season in October, November and December.
- Decrease speed when you approach deer near roadsides. Deer can “bolt” or change direction at the last minute.
- If you see a deer go across the road, decrease speed and be careful. Deer travel in groups, expect other deer to follow.
- Use emergency lights or flash your headlights to warn other drivers when deer are seen on or near the road.
- Use caution on roadways marked with deer crossing signs. These signs are put in areas that have had a large number of deer-vehicle collisions.

DRIVING EMERGENCIES

The most important rule in any emergency is do not panic. You have a better chance in an emergency if you do not let fear take over. In most emergencies, you will have a second or two to think before you act.

Here is what to do in different emergency situations:

TIRE BLOWOUT - A thumping sound can be a warning that a blowout is about to occur. If you hear it, get safely off the road and check your tires. If a tire blows out, hold the steering wheel tightly and slowly take your foot off the gas pedal. If your vehicle skids, handle it as you would on ice or snow. Do not brake until your vehicle is controlled. Leave the road when it is safe to do so.

LOSS OF A WHEEL - Handle this as you would a blowout. A thump or noise in the wheel can be a warning sound. Leave the roadway and stop. Then check your vehicle or have it checked.

STEERING FAILURE - If your vehicle suddenly will not respond when you steer, slowly take your foot off the gas pedal, turn on your emergency lights and keep your foot off the brake pedal while it is safe to do so. The balance of the vehicle will allow it to continue going straight, but a sudden change in speed could send it out of control. As the vehicle decreases speed, you can brake very carefully to bring it to a stop.

BRAKE FAILURE - If your brake pedal suddenly goes to the floor, try pumping it to increase pressure. If that does not help, use your emergency if you can apply it gradually- but use it gently. If you shift to a lower gear, it will help your vehicle decrease speed.

HEADLIGHT FAILURE - If your headlights suddenly go out, try your emergency lights, parking lights and directional signals. These may continue to work and can give you enough light to leave the roadway safely. If your headlights begin to dim, drive to a service station or pull off the road and go for help.

STUCK GAS PEDAL - Hook your shoe under the pedal and see if you can free it. If not, shift into neutral and use the brake to slow your vehicle and get off the road. Do not turn off the ignition as you could lose your steering control or lock your steering wheel.

RUNNING OFF THE PAVEMENT - If your wheels move off the pavement, do not suddenly steer or swerve back onto the pavement. Ease your foot off the gas pedal and brake gently. When your vehicle has decreased speed, check for traffic behind you, then turn carefully back onto the pavement.

VEHICLE APPROACHING HEAD-ON IN YOUR LANE - Decrease speed, pull over to the right and sound your horn to warn the other driver. Do not turn into the left lane. If you do, the other driver may suddenly recover and pull back into that lane, causing a head-on collision.